prepared a draft bill. Fourteen banks were selected for nationalization, as between them they accounted for some 85 or 90 percent of the deposits.

However, the *History* notes that D.N. Ghosh who was the Deputy Secretary in the Finance Ministry had been asked by Indira on July 17 to draft the Bill in 72 hours. She was apprehensive about the support she would receive from officials of the Finance Ministry and Law Ministry. Ghosh and Seshadri drafted the Bill with Jha overseeing their progress. S.K. Maitra, Joint Secretary in the Law Ministry, was also privy to the goings on as was A. Bakshi of the RBI, who was later to head the newly created Banking Department.[27] Patel recalls:

> On my own, I inserted a sentence in Mrs Gandhi's speech: 'This is not the first step in a new wave of nationalization. This, in fact, is the culmination of the process which began with the nationalization of Life Insurance and the Imperial Bank to occupy the commanding heights of finance.' The idea was to link with the past, to take away the revolutionary edge, and even more, to assure that no more nationalization would follow. Not a word of what I wrote was changed by Haksar or Mrs. Gandhi next morning—including what I had added on my own initiative. I think this, and the decision to exclude foreign and small banks, softened the blow. The Cabinet was a walk-over and the popular response in the country was one of open welcome. Even those affected had expected something of the sort and were anxious now to salvage what they could. It is remarkable how momentous decisions are made in the heat of political struggle. After this, Mrs. Gandhi was heralded as the angel of the poor and she made the most of *Garibi Hatao*.[28]

In a speech on All-India Radio, Indira said that a young democracy like India had to remain ever vigilant to prevent the domination of a few in the economic, political, and social fields and this meant that 'major banks should be not only socially controlled but publicly owned,' so that they could give credit not just to big business but to 'millions of farmers, artisans, and other self-employed persons.'[29] Some saw the move as a political quest masquerading as an ideological battle but there was no